in the absence of any openings in India, Veena decided to take it up, but only for a year, while I was in field area in Kohima. She left for Colombo on 14 July and was still in the process of settling down when she fell ill with dengue. She had to be rushed to hospital and was in the ICU for a couple of days. I rushed to Delhi, ready to take off for Colombo but Veena recovered enough that I did not have to make that trip.

Lt Gen Bipin Rawat, after his stint as MGGS, had taken over command of 3 Corps in late 2014. At that time, never could we have imagined that we would become the Chiefs of the Indian Army nor for that matter, that I would take over from him. He had seen me closely during the two war games and knew my capabilities quite well. I did not really have to impress him; it was too late for that. Whenever he used to visit, we would talk about many issues, not only about operations but also about the Army in general. On some issues, our ideas converged—on the gifting culture, for example, that had crept into the Army, or how standards of physical fitness were dropping. In fact, in one of the Divisional War Games, even Lt Gen Narasimhan had remarked that the Divisional Commanders looked slimmer and fitter than the Brigade Commanders. Though I had met him for the first time only when he came as the MGGS (Designate) for the Corps War Game, I developed a close bond and rapport with Gen Rawat.

Since the beginning of 2015, we had been keeping a close watch on the NSCN (K) camp at Zunheboto. This camp was where Niki Sumi, the self-styled commander of this group, used to stay, the main base being in Myanmar under its founder Khaplang. Niki Sumi's son used to study in the Sainik School, Punglwa, on the outskirts of Dimapur, and his wife stayed in Dimapur itself. After the winter break, the son had not rejoined the school, nor was his wife to be seen anywhere in

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